GEMS OF INDIA

SOWING THE SEEDS OF SUSTENANCE

Through decades of grassroots work, the Koppulas have translated ecological principles into livelihood security for thousands of marginal and tribal farmers

By **SONAL KHETARPAL**



If you ask Samamma, Tuljamma, Syamamma or anyone else in Bidakanne village about the Koppulas, their faces soften instantly. Smiles arrive first, followed by stories—and often tears. For decades, villagers say, Narsanna, 66, and Padma Koppula, 56, quietly changed the meaning of land, dignity and survival for families who once lived at the margins of rural life in the harsh Deccan outback. Always dressed in simple cotton clothes, the husband-and-wife environmentalist duo has have worked across Telangana and Andhra Pradesh since 1987, enabling farmers who were landless to gain land and self-reliance.

In 1999, the Koppulas turned their home in Sangareddy district of Telangana into a learning and community space called Aranya—Sanskrit for forest. What was once 11.5 acres of rocky wasteland was transformed into a lush natural farm built on the principles of permaculture and forest farming. The idea is straightforward: produce food without destroying the planet. "Aranya was created to be a functional farm to show small and marginal farmers how even one to three acres can serve all their needs," says Narsanna. "They can grow everything they need for a healthy diet, whether it is cereals, pulses, vegetables, fruits or nuts, along with cash crops and also rear animals to ensure economic independence."

Since 2014, the Koppulas have opened Aranya to the world through a 13-day residential permaculture course held every month for imbibing the principles of sustainable environment and natural ecosystems. Days begin at 6 am and often stretch late into the night, fuelled by discussions and farm work. Their daughter, daughter-in-law and community members help run the programme, ensuring that knowledge is passed across generations. "Land is the most ethical investment one can make," says Padma. "It offers fresh air, nutritious food and good health to the next generation." While running the course is demanding, the aim, she adds, is to ensure that learning remains accessible to anyone who can spare 13 days. Without advertising, each course draws 20-50 participants aged 18-60 from India and abroad. Over the past decade, 5,252 students from 72 countries have been trained at Aranya.

Ajaya Kumar Vemulapati, chairman, Andhra Pradesh Township and Infrastructure Development Corporation, likens the couple to *Kung Fu Panda*'s Grandmaster Oogway—the ancient tortoise mentor who represents calm authority, deep wisdom and hard-earned life experience. "Since the 1980s, their lives have been guided by a simple principle: give back to nature

BENEFICIARYSPEAK

"The greatest gift the Koppulas gave us was land ownership. Today, each of the 150 families here owns at least an acre of land. We practise regenerative farming, grow diverse crops, rear milch animals. Each family earns around Rs 10,000 per month and is self-reliant"

SAMAMMA, *Farmer from Bidakanne village, Sangareddy, Telangana*